

Ask Your Question on the Appropriate Website

Asking a Python question on a JavaScript forum or an algorithms question on a network security mailing list will likely be unproductive. Often, mailing lists and online forums have Frequently Asked Questions (FAQ) documents or description pages that explain which topics are appropriate to discuss. For example, the *python-dev* mailing list is about the Python language's design features, so it isn't a general Python help mailing list. The web page at <https://www.python.org/about/help/> can direct you to an appropriate place to ask whatever sort of Python question you have.

Summarize Your Question in the Headline

The benefit of posting your question to an online forum is that future programmers who have the same question can find it and its answers using an internet search. Be sure to use a headline that summarizes the question to make it easy for search engines to organize. A generic headline like "Help please" or "Why isn't this working?" is too vague. If you're asking your question in an email, a meaningful subject line tells your helper what your question is as they scan their inbox.

Explain What You Want the Code to Do

The question "Why doesn't my program work?" omits the critical detail of what you want your program to do. This isn't always obvious to your helper, because they don't know what your intention is. Even if your question is just "Why am I getting this error?" it helps to also say what your program's end goal is. In some cases, your helper can tell you if you need an entirely different approach, and you can abandon your problem rather than wasting time trying to solve it.

Include the Full Error Message

Be sure to copy and paste the entire error message, including the traceback. Merely describing your error, such as "I'm getting an out of range error," doesn't provide enough detail for your helper to figure out what is wrong. Also, specify whether you always encounter this error or if it's an